THE LAST STRAWS

When whistle-blowers inform on a person or organization they believe is engaged in illegal activity, they often use media partners to leak that information to the public. For example, a military analyst, Daniel Ellsberg, released the Pentagon Papers about the Vietnam War to reporters at the *New York Times* and other newspapers. Army Private Chelsea Manning gave her collection of Iraq War defense documents to the WikiLeaks whistle-blower website. Snowden found himself in a similar situation. If he gathered secret documents, how would he release them? Rather than do it himself, he decided to find partners in the media, people he trusted and who shared his beliefs about government overreach. He wanted to spread the documents to more than one source, so the leaks, once started, would be difficult for the government to stop.

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Daniel Ellsberg was a famous whistle-blower who released the Pentagon Papers in the 1970s.